

Poor in Print: Law, Figures and Poverty in Premodern Rome (1706–1742), Course: Law and Humanities (prof. Sara Menzinger). University of Roma Tre - 11 November 2025, Rome, Italy.

In this lecture I ask what law has to do with images. Moving from the usual terrain of legal history — statutes, court records, doctrinal texts — into the visual culture of early modern Rome, the session examines how iconographic and figurative sources represented the poor between 1706 and 1742. Its working hypothesis is that law is itself part of iconography. The historiography of poverty imagery is extensive, yet has tended to converge on a narrow repertoire — the vagrant, the homeless, the ragged and the infirm. This lesson tests this convention against a different body of evidence: a series of etchings of the poor published within the relatively unexpected Filippo Bonanni's *Catalogo degli Ordini Religiosi della Chiesa Militante* (Catalogue of the Religious Orders of the Militant Church, 1707–1710). Reading the *Catalogo* alongside contemporary legal writings, the session matches scholastic texts, bibliographical evidence, and figurative sources against one another. The aim is as much methodological as substantive. “Everything can help the researcher”. Provided some caution, even a collection of devotional etchings can turn into valuable evidence for legal historical research.

Edited with Claude (Anthropic)